

EFFECTS OF WATCHING A PRESIDENTIAL PRIMARY DEBATE

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Political debates, and the discussion among citizens they engender, lie at the heart of democracy. Coleman (2000) noted that

Election campaigns are obvious moments for debate to become important. An election is a key moment in a democratic society for the public to become activated and motivated to choose between competing political principles and policies. What better way to win the support of voters than to demonstrate in open debate the superiority of ones' fitness for power over that one ones' opponents? (p. 5)

Although political debates are often thought of as an American phenomenon, it is clear that they are not exclusively American, as Coleman's collection of readings demonstrates. Schrott (1990; Schrott & Lanoue, 1992) examined campaign debates in Germany. In 2002, Korea's primary campaign featured a debate ("GNP holds 2nd primary," 2002). Democracy undoubtedly benefits from a free flow of ideas, from interaction between candidates, as a political debate encourages.

A great deal has been written about general presidential debates (for example, books on this topic include Benoit & Wells, 1996; Bitzer & Rueter, 1980; Carlin & McKinney, 1994; Friedenberg, 1994; Hellweg, Pfau, & Brydon, 1992; Hinck, 1993; Jamieson & Birdsell, 1988; Kraus, 1962, 2000; Lanoue & Schrott, 1991). Far less scholarly attention has been devoted to understanding primary campaign debates. Nevertheless, in some ways primary debates are more important than their general campaign counterparts.

Historically there are simply far more primary debates than general election debates in America. Many more campaigns have featured primary than general debates. The first presidential debate, broadcast on radio, occurred when Thomas Dewey and Harold Stassen debated whether Communism should be outlawed in the 1948 Oregon primary. In 1960,

Kennedy prepared for the Nixon-Kennedy debates by debating Humphrey in West Virginia. Although record keeping is haphazard for primary debates, scholarship indicates that every campaign from 1948 to 2000, with the sole exception of 1964, included at least one primary debate (see Best & Hubbard, 2000; Davis, 1997). Additionally, in recent campaigns there have been many more primary than general campaign debates. In 1992, for example, there were 13 primary and 3 general debates; in 1996 there were 7 primary and 2 general election debates; and 22 primary debates and 3 general debates were held in 2000.

Furthermore, we should not assume that what we have learned about general election debates will necessarily transfer to primary debates. The audiences are different in primary debates. For example, Republican candidates need to focus on Republican voters in the primaries, rather than on Independents, undecided, or “Reagan Democrats.” Second, unlike general election debates, the opponents all belong to the same party in primary debates. Third, primary debates are more of a regional phenomenon than general election debates. Even more importantly, primary candidates are generally less well-known than the candidates who survive the primary campaign to become their parties’ nominees and debate in the general campaign (Best & Hubbard, 2000; Lanoue & Schrott, 1989; Pfau, 1988; Yawn, Ellsworth, Beatty, & Kahn, 1998). For example, in 1996, surely most voters were more familiar with Clinton and Dole, who faced one another in general campaign debates, than with primary debaters like Lamar Alexander, Pat Buchanan, Bob Dornan, Phil Gramm, Alan Keyes, Richard Lugar, Morrie Taylor. Surely Bush and Gore, the eventual nominees, were better known than Orrin Hatch or Gary Bauer. This means that the information primary debates provide has a greater potential for influencing voter impressions, attitudes, and vote choice than the information from general debates.

Although evidence of primary debate effects on voting behavior is scant, available evidence suggests that primary debates can influence voters. Ray (1961) analyzed the first primary debate between Dewey and Stassen (recall that Lincoln and Douglas were running for the Senate in their famous debates). Ray concluded that “Dewey must be adjudged the more effective of the two debaters,” reported that Dewey won the Oregon primary, and

noted that “There can be little doubt the Oregon victory (in the face of great odds [against Dewey; one poll gave Stassen a 70% to 30% margin] at the outset of the Oregon primary) greatly enhanced his prestige and did serious damage to Stassen’s bid for the nomination” (p. 266). Of course, Dewey won the Republican nomination, although he lost to Truman in the general campaign. Similarly, Kendall (2000) discussed the impact of the 1972 Humphrey-McGovern California primary debates:

The debates proved very damaging to McGovern. Not only did he plummet in the California polls, but Humphrey’s vivid characterizations of McGovern’s weaknesses provided rich material for Nixon in the fall campaign. Humphrey attacked sharply and effectively. (p. 78)

As the literature below shows, evidence indicates that primary debates enhance voter learning. Thus, presidential primary debates merit scholarly attention.

This study investigates the effects of viewing of presidential primary debates. We begin by reviewing the literature on presidential primary debates, focusing on those concerned with debate effects on audiences. Then we describe our purpose (including hypotheses and research questions) and method. This is followed by presentation of results and a discussion of the implications of these findings.

Previous Research on Presidential Primary Debates

Research offers an historical or critical view of the 1948 Dewey-Stassen radio debate (Ray, 1961), the 1960 Kennedy-Humphrey debate (Berquist, 1960; Stelzner, 1971), the 1968 Kennedy-McCarthy Debate (Murphy, 1972), and the 1980 Republican primary debates (Blankenship, Fine, & Davis, 1983). Three studies (Benoit, Blaney, & Pier, 1998; Benoit, Pier, Brazeal, McHale, Klyukovski, & Airne, 2002; Hellweg & Phillips, 1981) content analyzed primary debates. Three studies concerned the effects of debate format (Kane, 1987; Pfau, 1984, 1988). Given that we propose a study of audience effects, we will focus this review on empirical research on primary debate effects.

The earliest study of primary debate effects investigated the February 20, 1980 Republican primary debate (Lemert, Elliot, Nestvold, & Rarick, 1983). A strength of the study was that it employed telephone interviews with registered Republican voters (those who were most clearly the target audience for these debates). Unfortunately, the dependent measures were trivial. Those who agreed to watch this debate recalled more names of debate participants, did better at recalling the debate sponsor, and showed more interest in the campaign, than the control group. No attempt was made to measure learning about the candidates' issue positions or changes in evaluation of the candidates or voting preferences.

Hickman (1984/1985) related public opinion poll data to 1984 Democratic primary debates. Although contrasts were made between watchers and non-watchers, no significance tests are attempted. This makes it impossible to determine whether these differences are coincidental (especially given that poll data has an inherent margin of error).

Pfau (1987) used a pretest/posttest design to study the effects of three 1984 primary debates. He found that viewers learned about the candidate's issue positions, did so on a variety of issues, and did so among various groups of viewers (political party affiliation). Different debates produced different learning about the various candidates and, in one case, had a significant negative effect on learning about the non-participating incumbent's issue positions. He did not assess candidate evaluation or voting preferences.

A 1988 Democratic primary debate was studied by Lanoue and Schrott (1989). They noted that participants in the group that watched the debate were self-selected. Opinions toward the candidates changed after watching the debates and that these changes were more related to candidate images and debating styles than to issue positions. However, it is not clear how the issue questions were selected. That is, the authors do not report that these issues were addressed in the debate; if not, this is not a very strong test of effects from the debate.

An unusual 1988 primary debate (December 1987, Iowa) featuring both Republicans and Democrats was studied by Wall, Golden, and James (1988). They report pre-test/post-test changes in vote preference, and in perceptions of the candidates'

experience and abilities needed by a president, of the candidates' strength and persuasiveness as leaders, of the candidates' honesty and trustworthiness, similarity between the candidates' views and the respondent's views, and the extent to which the candidates understood Iowa's problems. However, because they did not report statistical analysis, we cannot be certain which, if any, of these shifts are significant changes.

Yawn, Ellsworth, Beatty, and Kahn (1998) examined the 1996 Republican debate in Arizona. They studied the audience who was physically present at the debates, arguing that "Directly observing the debate makes the experience more vivid" (p. 158) and observe that "we are confident about generalizing our findings to people who attend primary debates" (p. 159). However, because most voters watch the debates on television, the generalizability of their results is sharply limited. They reported changes in perceived viability, electability, debate performance, and vote preference.

The final, and most extensive, study on presidential primary debates concerned a 1995 Republican debate from New Hampshire (Best & Hubbard, 2000). They compared the difference between pretest and posttest scores of watchers and nonwatchers of this contest. Watchers reported that they would be more likely to vote in the primary, indicating a higher level of interest in the campaign. Those who viewed debates experienced significant changes on their feeling thermometer scores for six of ten candidates, and they argued that the magnitude of these shifts seemed higher than changes from watching a Mondale-Reagan debate in 1984.

They also divided candidates into the front-runner (Dole), contenders (Alexander, Buchanan, Forbes, Gramm, Lugar, and Specter) and long-shots (Dornan, Keyes and Taylor) according to pretest scores. The front-runner was perceived significantly more positively by watchers than nonwatchers, as were the contenders (although the change was smaller), whereas the long-shots were viewed more negative. The front-runner was seen as significantly more likely to win the nomination and the long shots were thought of as less likely to win the nomination by watchers (the difference for contenders was non-significant). The front runner was perceived by watchers to be more likely to win the

general campaign in nominated by the Republican Party, as were the contenders (to a lesser but still significant extent), while long-shots were seen as less likely to win the general campaign. Finally, Best and Hubbard (2000) presented evidence which suggests that discussion of various issues by the candidates led to shifts in perceived importance of those issues by debate watchers. However, they did not report that these shifts were significant.

Thus, the research on presidential primary debates is highly suggestive of effects on audience knowledge and attitudes. However, limitations inhere in each study we reviewed. Additional research could reinforce the present state of knowledge.

Purpose

This study investigates the effects of watching debates on candidate evaluation, issue knowledge, policy issue importance, preferred candidate on specific policy issues, viability (in the primary), electability (in the general campaign), vote preference, and vote confidence in a 1999 presidential primary debate. Specifically, we studied viewer reactions to the November 21, 1999 Arizona Republican debate featuring Orrin Hatch, Steve Forbes, Alan Keyes, and John McCain (Gary Bauer and George W. Bush declined to participate).

We adopt the theoretical perspective articulated in the Functional Theory of Political Campaign Discourse (Benoit, 1999), which argues that candidate messages can address two important topics: policy (issues) and character (image, personality). In a presidential primary, voters choose which member of the party should win the party's nomination. Thus, political party membership cannot be a basis for a vote decision (i.e., being a Republican cannot help voters choose between Republicans George W. Bush and John McCain). This means that voters have essentially two bases for their vote decision: policy (issues) and character (personalities or images). Pomper (1975) argues that these factors can be important enough for some voters to cause vote defections in the general elections: Many voters "change their partisan choice from one election to the next, and these changes are most closely related to their positions on the issues and their assessment of the abilities of the candidates" (p. 10). These are possible bases for making decisions about

candidates in the primary campaign as well. Furthermore, public opinion poll data from 1976-2000 reported in Table 1 reveals that a portion of the electorate cites each factor as the principal basis for their vote choice.

Table 1
Most Important Vote Determinant: Policy or Character

Campaign	Policy	Character	Poll
2000	90%	8%	Princeton Survey Research Associates 10/7-11/99
1996	65%	27%	NBC/ <i>Wall Street Journal</i> , 10/19-22/96
1992	143%*	16%	Harris Poll, 11/3/92
1988	59%	16%	<i>USA Today</i> , 1/21-28/88
1984	87%	7%	<i>LA Times</i> , 2/4-9/84
1980	59%	34%	<i>LA Times</i> , 10/5-9/80
1976	57%	36%	CBS/ <i>New York Times</i> , 10/24-27/76

*Respondents were allowed to pick the two most important factors in this poll. "Don't know" and "unsure" responses are not reported here. All polls obtained on-line from Lexis/Nexis Academic Universe.

Based on this analysis, primary candidates have at least three options available to them for persuading voters that they are the best choice. First, candidates may influence (create or change) the impressions voters have of them. For example, a 2000 primary television spot (“Character”) from Steve Forbes argued that “He’s honest. He always gives a straight answer.” Surely the point of this utterance was to convince voters that Forbes possesses a particular personal quality or character trait (honesty) and that this trait should incline them to vote for him. Second, candidates may attempt to change which issues are most important to voters. In 2000, for example, John McCain (who sponsored the McCain-Feingold finance reform bill in the Senate) is the candidate who has worked hardest for campaign reform. However, relatively few voters consider campaign finance reform a high priority. A Harris Poll conducted September 17-21, 1999, found that when asked to name the two most important issues for government to address, only 1% mentioned campaign finance. A McCain advertisement (“Proud Again”) seemed to be an attempt to persuade voters that they should consider this to be an important issue: “John McCain knows getting the \$100,000 checks out of politics will get us our government back.” Finally, a candidate may attempt to convince voters that he or she is the best candidate to deal with a particular issue or problem. In the current campaign, for example, this TV spot (“Insure”) for Al Gore declared that he is “The only candidate who protects Medicare and preserves Medicaid.” This utterance seems aimed at voters who consider Medicare and/or Medicaid to be important issues, arguing that Gore would be the best vote choice for such voters. This study is designed to determine whether watching a presidential primary debate can change viewer attitudes in any of these three areas. We also assess four more global attitudes: viability, electability, vote choice, and vote confidence.

In this investigation we test four hypotheses:

H1. Watching a primary debate will create or change evaluations of the candidates.

H2. Watching a primary debate will change viewer attitudes concerning the relative importance of the policy topics discussed in that debate.

H3. Watching a primary debate will change voter attitudes concerning the preferred candidate on the policy topics addressed in that debate.

H4. Watching a primary debate will change perceptions of viability, electability, voting preferences, and vote confidence.

Together, these hypotheses will add to our understanding of the effects of presidential primary debates on debate watchers.

Method

Participants

Fifty-seven individuals participated in this study. Participants were 39% male and the mean age was 21 years. While there were equal numbers of self-identified Democrats and Republicans (21% each), more than half claimed no political affiliation (53%) or another party (4%). More than half claimed to be moderates (54%), while the remaining participants identified themselves as either liberals (25%) or conservatives (19%).

Design and Procedures

We used a pretest-posttest design to test the hypotheses. Participants completed a preliminary questionnaire and then signed up to participate in the second part of the study (they were not informed of the nature of the second session). When they arrived in the lab about a week later, they watched a video-tape of the debate in groups of 2-12, and then completed the posttest. The debate was approximately one hour in length.

Methodologically, the pretest-posttest design was a more attractive alternative to a posttest only design. The pretest-posttest design allows researchers to assess changes in the respondents. Benoit, Webber, and Berman's (1998) study of a 1996 general debate, for example, contrasted subjects who watched that debate with others who did not view it. However, they were not able to assign subjects to the two conditions, which meant that they could not make causal claims from their data. A pretest-posttest design has a clear advantage over a posttest only design.

We inserted a delay of approximately a week (between the pretest and the second session watching the debate and completing the posttest) so that questions on the pretest would not be salient when the subjects watched the debate. That is, we wanted them to watch the debate without specifically thinking about or looking for the items that comprised our questionnaire (we also did not want them to watch the debate in a group of 70 or 80 participants). The existence of this delay means it is conceivable that some of our participants were exposed to other campaign messages during that delay. If so, this would mean differences between the pretest and the posttest could be attributable to those other messages. We believe this possibility is unlikely. We collected data in Missouri, which held its primary long after we collected data. No television spots had run and no debates had occurred in that state at the point data were collected. Therefore, we judged it highly unlikely that an appreciable segment of our participants would show effects on our posttest that were attributable to other campaign messages.

Measures

Candidate Evaluation. Using a 1 (highly) to 9 (not at all) Likert-type response format, candidate evaluation was assessed with the following 4 items: honest, experienced, energetic, and understands viewpoint of ordinary people (Benoit et al., 1998). A “don’t know” option was an available response. Participants indicated their evaluation for each candidate pertinent to the debate that was watched. Therefore, as there were four Republican candidates in the debate, participants answered a total of 16 evaluation items (4 evaluation items X 4 candidates). Average coefficient *alpha* for the candidate evaluation items was .86 for the pretest and .89 for the posttest.

Issue Importance. Participants rated 11 issues on the importance of each as a factor in their vote for President. Importance was assessed at both the pretest and the posttest. The authors viewed the debate prior to preparing the questionnaire in order to determine which issues were actually discussed in the debate. On a 0 (very unimportant) to 10 (extremely important) scale, participants rated the importance of social security, income tax, health care,

Supreme Court, U.S. Armed Forces abroad, policy toward Russia, gun control, America's moral crisis, abortion, education, and campaign finance reform.

Preferred Candidate on Issues. Using the same 11 issues rated for "issue importance," participants were asked to identify which of the four candidates they perceived as closest to their own viewpoint on the issue. Participants indicated the preferred candidate at pretest and after the debate on the posttest.

Electability and Viability. Electability, representing a candidate's realistic chance to win the Presidency if becoming the Republican nominee, was measured on a scale of 0 (no chance of winning) to 100 (excellent chance of winning). Viability, representing a candidate's chance to win the Republican nomination, was also measured on a 0 to 100 scale. Participants reported electability and viability for all candidates contesting the nomination at the time: Bauer, Bush, Forbes, Hatch, Keyes, and McCain.

Voting Preferences. Vote choice was assessed in the pretest and posttest with: "If you were going to vote in a Republican primary, which candidate would you pick today." Participant response options were Bauer, Bush, Forbes, Hatch, Keyes, and McCain. All participants then indicated their voting confidence with: "On a scale of 100 (extremely sure) to 1 (very uncertain), how confident are you that the candidate you checked is the best candidate."

Results

Paired t-tests were employed to analyze Hypotheses 1, 2, and part of Hypothesis 4. The remainder of the hypotheses were tested with the *Cochran-Mantel-Haenszel Chi-Square* test, a nonparametric statistic used to analyze repeated measures nominal-level data.

Hypothesis 1. This hypothesis received support. First, the mean number of candidate evaluation items on which the participants had no attitude dropped significantly from the pretest ($M=18.44$, $SD=14.35$) to the posttest ($M=1.82$, $SD=6.11$), $t(56)=8.92$, $p<.001$. Thus, watching the debate clearly led to the *formation* of candidate evaluations. Additionally, there were significant *changes* in candidate evaluations after watching the

debate. Respondents viewed Keyes as more honest after the debate ($\underline{M}=7.36$, $\underline{SD}=1.62$) than before the debate ($\underline{M}=6.41$, $\underline{SD}=1.65$), $t(21)=2.99$, $p < .01$. Respondents also viewed McCain as more honest after the debate ($\underline{M}=6.81$, $\underline{SD}=1.69$) than before ($\underline{M}=6.06$, $\underline{SD}=1.90$), $t(31)=2.39$, $p < .05$. Respondents considered Forbes as more experienced after the debate ($\underline{M}=5.79$, $\underline{SD}=2.21$) than before the debate ($\underline{M}=4.91$, $\underline{SD}=2.39$), $t(33)=2.06$, $p < .05$. McCain was also perceived as more experienced after the debate ($\underline{M}=7.58$, $\underline{SD}=1.37$) than before ($\underline{M}=7.07$, $\underline{SD}=1.27$), $t(31)=2.36$, $p < .05$. Keyes was observed as more energetic after the debate ($\underline{M}=7.04$, $\underline{SD}=1.64$) than before ($\underline{M}=8.31$, $\underline{SD}=1.01$), $t(25)=3.95$, $p < .01$. Finally, McCain was perceived as more understanding of people after the debate ($\underline{M}=6.65$, $\underline{SD}=1.70$) than before ($\underline{M}=5.89$, $\underline{SD}=2.03$), $t(34)=2.35$, $p < .05$. See Table 2.

Table 2
Changes in Candidate Evaluations from Pretest to Posttest

	Forbes	Hatch	Keyes	McCain
Honesty				
Pre to Post Change	.52	.67	.95**	.75*
<u>N</u>	(31)	(21)	(22)	(32)
Experience				
Pre to Post Change	.88*	.83	.04	.51*
<u>N</u>	(34)	(24)	(23)	(33)
Energetic				
Pre to Post Change	.20	-.52	1.27**	.17
<u>N</u>	(35)	(25)	(26)	(36)
Understands Ordinary People				
Pre to Post Change	.63	.13	.67	.77*
<u>N</u>	(35)	(24)	(24)	(35)

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

Hypothesis 2. The perceived importance of two topics addressed in the debate changed significantly from pretest to posttest. Social security increased in importance from pretest ($\underline{M}=5.95$, $\underline{SD}=2.70$) to posttest ($\underline{M}=6.96$, $\underline{SD}=2.26$), $t(53)=2.99$, $p<.005$. Likewise, America's moral crisis increased in importance from pretest ($\underline{M}=5.60$, $\underline{SD}=3.17$) to posttest ($\underline{M}=6.49$, $\underline{SD}=3.34$), $t(53)=1.98$, $p=.05$. None of the other nine issues changed significantly in perceived importance.

Hypothesis 3. Substantial changes were detected from pretest to posttest on the preferred candidate for every one of the issues investigated. Table 3 shows that, at the very minimum, 60% of the participants changed their preferred candidate for each of the nine issues discussed in the debate. As many as 74% changed their preferred candidate on some issues. These results supported Hypothesis 3.

Table 3
Changes in Preferred Candidates from Pretest to Posttest on Issues Addressed in
Debate

Issue	Change in Preferred Candidate	χ^2
Health care	73.7%	15.8**
Supreme Court	71.9%	13.8**
U.S. Armed Forces abroad	74.4%	14.7**
Policy toward Russia	71.9%	22.6**
Gun control	71.9%	17.1**
America's moral crisis	73.7%	16.3**
Abortion	70.2%	12.3*
Education	70.2%	22.1**
Campaign finance reform	59.6%	16.3**
Social Security	66.7%	14.8**
Income tax	59.6%	19.5**

For all χ^2 , df=4; * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$

Hypothesis 4. As predicted, post-debate scores about the candidates' electability (realistic chance to win the presidency) and viability (realistic chance to win the Republican nomination) differed significantly for almost every candidate. Overall, participants believed that Forbes, Hatch, Keyes, and McCain were more electable after viewing the debate ($p < .001$), Bush was perceived as less electable ($p < .05$), and no statistically significant change was detected for Bauer. The results and significance levels for viability are identical.

As predicted, viewing the primary debate led to a significant change in voting preferences, $\chi^2(5, N=57)=30.81$, $p < .001$. Table 4 also provides the net change in voting

intention from pretest to posttest. Just over two-thirds (68%, $N=39$) of the debate viewers changed their voting preference. Furthermore, respondents indicated they were also more confident that their selection was the best candidate after the debate ($M=66.5\%$, $SD=23.6$) than in the pretest ($M=40.7\%$, $SD=33.0$), $t(56)=5.03$, $p<.001$. Therefore, Hypothesis 4 was supported.

Table 4
Percent Change in Candidate Perceptions from Pretest to Posttest

Candidate	Electability	Viability	Change in Vote Percent
Forbes	+ 18.3	+ 18.0	+15.8
Hatch	+ 19.9	+ 15.1	+ 1.8
Keyes	+ 23.3	+ 23.2	+ 21.0
McCain	+ 15.4	+ 17.3	+ 15.8
Bush	- 6.4	- 6.0	- 45.6
Bauer	+ 0.4	- 3.7	0.0

Discussion

This study provides strong support for the ability of primary debates to change attitudes and voting intentions. Changes occurred in evaluations of the candidates' character. Voters who lacked information about a candidate formed impressions after watching a primary debate, and, when voters come to the debate with attitudes about candidates, they often changed their evaluations of the candidates after watching the debate. While we cannot attribute causality to any particular remark in the debate, it seems likely that voters were responding to comments like this one from Alan Keyes: "And we need candidates who aren't so interested in pandering for their votes, for your votes, that they're only willing to look you in the eye and speak the truth." This kind of comment stresses Keyes's concern for honesty, one quality presumably important for a presidential candidate to possess (and, indeed, Keyes was perceived as more honest after viewing the debate).

Debates also have the power to influence voter attitudes on issues or policy questions. First, although issue importance is relatively stable, two of the nine issues discussed in the debate were perceived as more important after the debate. Thus, debates have the potential to perform an agenda-setting function (see, e.g., McCombs & Shaw, 1972; Shaw & McCombs, 1977). Wanta (1997) indicates that "agenda-setting researchers have devoted relatively little attention to the president-public relationship" (p. 80). The literature on agenda-setting functions of debates is scant and limited to general election debates (Becker, Weaver, Graber, & McCombs, 1979 concluded there was no agenda setting effect in the 1976 presidential debates; Swanson & Swanson, 1978, said there was; see also Gadziala & Becker, 1983; McLeod, Durall, Ziemke, & Bybee, 1979). Again, we cannot trace these effects to specific remarks in the debate, but one of the issues that became more important in this encounter was Social Security. The candidates used the phrase "Social Security" 21 times in their answers. For example, Hatch argued that this is a problem of increasing importance:

By the year 2025, we're going to have 75 percent more people on Social Security than we have today. By the year 2035, we will only have 71 percent of the revenues

necessary to pay for 100 percent of Social Security. So we have to face these problems. When Social Security was instituted, there were 46 workers for every one on Social Security. Today, there are 3.4 workers. By the year 2035, there'll be two workers for every one on Social Security.

Comments like this apparently functioned to increase the perceived importance of this issue. The fact that two of the nine issues changed in importance shows that primary debate have the potential to serve an agenda setting function.

Second, beliefs about which candidate was preferable on these issue changed after viewing the debates. For example, Forbes gave viewers a reason to prefer him on health care:

And again, my campaign has put forth specific proposals to put the patient in charge of health care resources. It works, whether it's medical savings accounts, giving people on Medicare the choice of several hundred different health care plans, just as civilians who work for the federal government have today.

Thus, debates can influence the issue component of vote decisions: probably more by influencing attitudes about the preferred candidates on an issue, but also by influencing the perceived importance of issues.

The ultimate question in a campaign is who will receive a citizen's vote. Perceptions of viability and electability changed after watching the debate. Voting intentions shifted after watching the debate: two-thirds of participants changed their voting preferences. Furthermore, participants expressed more confidence in their vote choice after watching the debate, presumably because they now have more information on which to base their voting decision. There can be no doubt that watching primary debates has significant effects on attitudes, perceptions, and voting intentions.

These results have clear implications for candidates. Debate participants gained from the exposure they obtained from primary debates. Each candidate who participated in the debate was perceived as a more viable candidate, one who is more capable of winning

the Republican nomination. Each participant was also seen as more electable, or better able to win the general election in November.

It is also interesting that attitudes toward non-participants were influenced by the debates. Although perceptions of Bauer's viability and electability did not change, he was never mentioned in the debate. On the other hand, Bush, who was the front-runner, was discussed in the debate. For example, Forbes made these comments about Bush in this debate: "Governor Bush, George W. Bush's proposal on Social Security is typical of Washington, and that is, make a promise, and then find a way to retract that promise, break that promise;" "When you address questions to George W. Bush, you rarely get an answer, or you get something that obviously comes off a teleprompter, or that his tutors have cued him on just before the question and answer." Bush's perceived viability and electability dropped substantially after respondents watched the debate, presumably because of attacks like these in the debate (and, may we add, attacks without the possibility of defenses from Bush).

Global evaluations toward the candidates as measured by the "feeling thermometer" also increased for all four participants and dropped for the two no-shows. This means that perceptions of both those candidates who participate as well as those who avoiding a primary debate can be influenced by a primary debate.

It is important to mention one limitation of this study. Because we considered multiple issues and character traits, and several candidates, the number of statistical tests conducted means that some of our results could have been significant by chance.

Conclusion

First, there is clear evidence that watching primary debates can have a variety of beneficial effects on debate participants. This message form influenced evaluations of the candidates (character), importance of issues (agenda setting), candidate preference on issues, perceived viability and electability, voting preference, and certainty of vote choice. Clearly, primary debates have the potential to influence voters and affect the fortunes of candidates.

Evaluations of the candidates were formed (if voters did not already have impressions) and changed (if they had impressions of the candidates prior to the debate) as a result of watching the debate. Those who engaged in the debate were seen as more viable and more electable. Somewhat surprisingly, on two of the nine issues, the debate increased the perceived importance of issues to viewers. Perceptions of which candidate was the best choice (closest to the viewer's own standpoint) on each issue also changed. Thus, primary debates, perhaps because they occur early in the season, before attitudes become firmly-held, can have significant impact on those who watch them (Best & Hubbard, 2000; Lanoue & Schrott, 1989; Pfau, 1988; Yawn, Ellsworth, Beatty, & Kahn, 1998).

Interestingly, the Arizona debate also had significant effects on those who chose not to debate. In the 2000 primary campaign, the front-running Republican candidate, George W. Bush, skipped the first three Republican debates (October 22, 1999; October 28, 1999; November 21, 1999). Gary Bauer also chose not to participate. The results of this study suggest that these candidates missed an opportunity to favorably impress viewers, while providing an opportunity for opponents to narrow the gap to some extent. Bush's lead may have been sufficient for him to be able to shrug off the gains his opponents enjoyed; Bauer, on the other hand, clearly did not have this luxury. Furthermore, in tighter contests missing a debate could make an important difference. Voters who watched the debate believed Bush to be significantly less viable, less electable, and had less favorable impressions of Bush. Bauer, who was ignored in the debate, failed to make any gains.

Although fewer people watch a given primary than a particular general debate, there are many more primary than general debates. Furthermore, the number of voters needed to have an impact on a caucus (like Iowa) or an early primary (like New Hampshire) is not that large. Given the fact that primary debates are held earlier in the campaign season, when voters have less information about the candidates, these message forms have real potential to influence voters. This study of the November 21, 1999 Arizona primary debate documents the power of these political message to influence attitudes, perceptions, and voting preferences. There can be effects for those candidates who choose to debate and those who

choose to avoid the debate. Clearly, they merit more scholarly attention. Scholars should also make efforts to encourage more voters to watch these encounters, because debate watchers can form, or modify, attitudes because of these messages.

References

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